

# Appendix I — Online Safety Act 2023

## Compliance Opinion

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**Subject of opinion:** DEQUAD (DEQUAD Ltd in formation), operated at <https://dequad.co.uk>

**Author of internal assessment:** Yusuf Quadri (Founder) **External counsel of record:** [Law firm to be appointed — recommended panel: Bristows, Mishcon, Wiggins, Schillings] **Date of latest review:** \_\_\_\_\_

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### I.1 Purpose

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This document is an internal compliance opinion summarising DEQUAD's position under the **Online Safety Act 2023** ("OSA") and is intended to demonstrate to UK Endorsement Services Ltd that the applicant has identified the obligations applicable to the business and has built the product with them in mind.

A signed external legal opinion from a UK-qualified solicitor in good standing will be commissioned during Month 2 post-endorsement and attached to this appendix at the next UKES contact point.

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### I.2 Categorisation of DEQUAD under the OSA

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| Category                                     | Status                   | Reason                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Regulated user-to-user service               | <b>Yes</b>               | Users (verified students) share content with other users via messages and profile fields                     |
| Search service                               | No                       | DEQUAD does not provide search across third-party content                                                    |
| Likely to be accessed by children (under 18) | <b>Yes</b><br>(residual) | Although DEQUAD targets verified university students (predominantly 18+), some UK undergraduates start at 17 |
| Category 1 service (Ofcom designation)       | <b>No</b><br>(forecast)  | DEQUAD's user base and functionality will not meet the Category 1 thresholds during the endorsement window   |

**Practical implication:** DEQUAD is a **Category 2B-equivalent** user-to-user service with residual exposure to under-18 users. The applicable duties are summarised in §I.3.

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## I.3 Applicable duties

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| Duty                                        | Section          | DEQUAD design response                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Illegal-content risk assessment             | OSA s. 9, s. 10  | Completed; reviewed annually. See §I.4 below                                                                               |
| Illegal-content safety duties               | OSA s. 10        | Real-time keyword scanning + escalation to DSL; reporting flow built; takedown SLA defined                                 |
| Children's risk assessment                  | OSA s. 11, s. 12 | Completed under assumption of residual under-18 access. See §I.5                                                           |
| Children's safety duties                    | OSA s. 12        | High-risk safety setting default-on for all users; no algorithmic recommendation of strangers to flagged-under-18 accounts |
| Content-reporting and complaints procedures | OSA s. 17        | "Report a profile" feature live since 2026; complaints SLA 4 hours human triage                                            |
| User empowerment (Cat 1 only)               | OSA s. 14        | Not applicable (Cat 2B)                                                                                                    |
| Freedom of expression / privacy             | OSA s. 22        | DPIA documents necessity + proportionality of every safeguarding scan                                                      |
| Record-keeping                              | OSA s. 23        | All safeguarding events logged for 7 years; risk-assessment versions retained                                              |
| Designated content moderator                | OSA s. 56        | DSL appointed; backup DSL named                                                                                            |
| Ofcom information requests                  | OSA s. 100       | Process in place: 7-day response SLA                                                                                       |

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## I.4 Illegal-content risk assessment summary

| Priority illegal content type           | Risk on DEQUAD       | Why                                                                                                  | Mitigation                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Terrorism (s. 59)                       | Very low             | Closed UK university network; no anonymous posting; no public discoverability                        | Standard keyword scan + reporting flow                                                                              |
| Child sexual abuse (CSAM)               | Low                  | Verified .ac.uk users (16+ at oldest UK universities); no photo-sharing without face-detection check | Photo upload moderation queue; CSAM detection partner to be appointed Y1                                            |
| Hate offences                           | Medium               | Student demographics include vulnerable groups; loneliness apps attract abuse vectors                | Real-time slur detection (already live); zero-tolerance ban policy; appeals route                                   |
| Harassment / stalking                   | Medium               | Direct-message functionality enables targeted abuse                                                  | Per-message safeguarding scan; "block + report" combined flow                                                       |
| Controlling / coercive behaviour        | Medium               | Closed-network apps can enable controlling relationships                                             | Pattern detection on per-conversation cadence; safeguarding nudges; partnership with Refuge for IDVA referrals (Y2) |
| Drugs / firearms / sale of stolen goods | Low                  | Verified-student network with strict TOS; no marketplace functionality                               | TOS prohibition + reporting + ban                                                                                   |
| Fraud                                   | Low                  | No payment between users; no marketplace                                                             | Stripe-only billing flow; users cannot solicit money                                                                |
| Suicide and self-injury content         | <b>High residual</b> | The platform's safeguarding role makes this content type uniquely relevant                           | Per-message scan + DSL escalation + Samaritans/Shout signposting (live); evaluated quarterly                        |
| Encouragement of suicide (s. 184 OSA)   | High residual        | As above                                                                                             | Active scanning; "encouragement" patterns distinct from "expression of distress" — DSL judges                       |
| Animal cruelty / extreme pornography    | Very low             | No mass-media upload; profile photos only                                                            | Profile-photo moderation queue                                                                                      |

The full Illegal Content Risk Assessment (ICRA) is kept on file and reviewed annually. Methodology aligns with Ofcom's **Online Safety: Illegal Harms Guidance** (December 2024).

## I.5 Children's risk assessment summary

DEQUAD is designed for verified UK university students. The platform's verification gate (active `.ac.uk` email) excludes the vast majority of under-18 users. However:

- A small number of UK undergraduate students begin their first year aged 17 (typically birthday-rule edge cases).
- Some Foundation-Year and Access course students at partner FE institutions may be 16+.

The Children's Risk Assessment therefore treats DEQUAD as a service with **residual exposure to under-18 users** and applies the corresponding precautions:

| Precaution                                                       | Implementation                                                                                              |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Age-assurance at sign-up                                         | Self-declared birth date + verified university email. Stronger age-verification under evaluation for Year 2 |
| Default privacy-protective settings for likely under-18 accounts | No discoverability via search; no exposure to adult users >5 years older without dual opt-in                |
| Children's content-design code (ICO AADC) alignment              | Designed in from launch: data minimisation, no profiling, no dark patterns                                  |
| Education and reporting tools tailored for younger users         | Plain-English help; one-tap "I need help" route to Childline (for under-18 self-identified users)           |

## I.6 Designated roles and accountabilities

| OSA-mandated role                                     | Person / function                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Notes                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Senior Manager Responsible for Compliance (OSA s. 56) | Yusuf Quadri, CEO (with Yusuff Adeagbo, CTO, as deputy)                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Joint founder accountability documented in board minutes |
| Designated Safeguarding Lead                          | <i>Yusuf Quadri, CEO, personally (a qualified safeguarding professional) through Y1–Y2; a dedicated part-time Safeguarding &amp; Trust Lead is planned for Y3, contingent on 2+ paying universities and funded entirely by revenue — see Business Plan §18.3</i> | Job description in Appendix G                            |
| Data Protection Officer                               | <i>Outsourced fractional throughout Y1–Y2 (e.g. The DPO Centre, low-cost pay-as-you-go); an in-house FTE DPO is not assumed in this 3-year plan and would only be considered later if data-processing scale justifies it</i>                                     |                                                          |
| Ofcom liaison point                                   | Yusuf Quadri, CEO (Y1); transition to in-house counsel Y3                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                          |

## I.7 Engagement with the regulator (Ofcom)

| Activity                                                             | Status                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Registered for Ofcom's small-platform information service            | Pending Month 1 post-endorsement                                |
| Subscribed to Ofcom guidance updates                                 | ✅ Live                                                          |
| Familiarity with Ofcom's Guidance for Smaller Providers (2025)       | ✅ Reviewed                                                      |
| Plan for Ofcom transparency reports (if Cat 1 designation triggered) | Documented; no current Cat 1 forecast within endorsement window |

## I.8 External legal opinion — scope of work to be commissioned

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The external legal opinion to be commissioned in Month 2 post-endorsement will cover:

1. Confirmation of DEQUAD's categorisation under the OSA;
2. Sufficiency of the Illegal Content and Children's Risk Assessments;
3. Sufficiency of the content-reporting and complaints procedures;
4. Adequacy of record-keeping;
5. Risk register for foreseeable Ofcom enforcement;
6. Boilerplate Terms of Service and Acceptable Use Policy review;
7. Confirmation that the founder's senior-manager-responsible accountability is appropriately recorded.

Estimated cost: **£8,000–£12,000** (firm fee dependent). Budgeted in Year-1 P&L (Appendix F).

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## I.9 Statement

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The applicant has read the Online Safety Act 2023 in full, has read the Ofcom illegal-content and children's-safety guidance, and has designed DEQUAD's product, processes, and policies to comply with the duties applicable to a Category 2B-equivalent user-to-user service. The applicant will obtain external legal confirmation of this position within the first six months of operation and will produce that opinion at the 6-month UKES contact point.

**Signed:** \_\_\_\_\_ Yusuf Quadri

**Date:** \_\_\_\_\_